



The Stone Age is **99 percent** of human history!

What is the Stone Age?

The Stone Age covers almost all of human history. It was the time when humans used stone tools. Through most of the Stone Age, people were hunter-gatherers. They looked for food by hunting, fishing, and collecting plants and fruit to eat. Gradually, early people developed to live in groups and communicate with each other, much like we do today. The Stone Age can be divided into three main periods, as shown here.

Old Stone Age (Paleolithic)

This is the biggest Stone Age time period as it covers more than 3 million years of human history. It is the time when people started to develop, or evolve, in many important ways, such as by making simple stone tools.



Flint hand ax



Harpoon tips

How people developed

Our ancestors learned to make stone tools and this allowed them to get food much more easily. Over many generations, this resulted in humans becoming cleverer and better at toolmaking, with larger brains and different bodies, eventually becoming the species we are today, *Homo sapiens*.



The shape and size of the skulls of early humans changed over time.

Early human

Living in Africa, Europe, and Asia between 600,000 and 200,000 years ago, *Homo heidelbergensis* is the direct ancestor of humans and Neanderthals. They could hunt, make complex stone tools, and use fire.